STRATEGY GUIDE

A Tavola!

How to play each of the five games well, once you know the rules.

These tips are written for the A Tavola! rules, which differ in places from the traditional Italian games. Read the rulebook first; this guide picks up where its short tips leave off.

The cards worth remembering

Card	10	9	8	7	6	5	4 to 1
Hat points	11	10	4	3	2	0	0
Stars	1	1	3	1	1	1	0

Hats count in Chef's Choice and Head Chef (120 in the deck). Stars count in Crowd Pleasers (32 in the deck, plus 3 for the last trick). In every game a higher number beats a lower one of the same suit.

Three habits that help in every game

Count what has gone. There are four of every number and ten cards in every suit. You don't need to remember everything: pick the cards that matter in the game you are playing (the 10s and 9s, the 8s, the trumps) and follow those.

Value playing late. Whoever plays last sees every other card first. When you have to play early, risk little; when you play last, take what is on offer.

Play for the team. With a partner, the best card is often one that helps their trick or their pile, not one that wins by itself.

Hot Potato

Patata Bollente · 2 to 30 players

How low is too low depends on the table. The more players, the more likely someone holds a card worse than yours. When nobody has passed to you, this is a good guide:

Players still in	3	5	8	12 or more
Pass if you hold	5 or lower	4 or lower	3 or lower	1 or 2

After a swap, compare the two cards. If the card you were given is higher than the one you gave away, keep it: the player before you now holds your old card, so you cannot be the lowest. If it is lower, pass it on: you are already behind at least one player.

Show an 8 the moment someone tries to pass to you. It is the only card that can refuse a swap. A 9 or a 10 has no such protection and can be taken from you in exchange for a 1, so never feel safe just because you were dealt one.

Read the table before you decide. The cards of players who are out lie face up, and earlier rounds of this deal have gone under the deck. If most of the 1s and 2s have been seen, a 3 is now a dangerous card; if none have, it is safer than it looks.

Dealer: the deck is a blind swap. Use the same table as everyone else. The exception is when a card has just been passed to you and it is higher than the one you gave: you are safe, so keep it.

Ties all lose. Holding the same low number as another player does not save you, so a shared 2 is as bad as a lone 2.

Mop Up

Scarpetta · 2 or 3 players, or 4 in teams

Leave more than 10 on the plate. No card is higher than 10, so a plate that adds up to 11 or more cannot be wiped clean in one play. Before you put a card down, add up what will be left.

Playing onto an empty plate, choose a number that has been seen. A single card can only be swept by its match. If two or three of that number are already in the piles, the chance that the next player holds the last one is small.

Low cards are sweep fuel. 1s, 2s and 3s add up in many ways and make a plate easy to clear. Take them off the plate when it costs you nothing, and think twice before laying one down.

Know which capture to take. When you have a choice, this order is usually right: the Pizza (the 8 of Forno, a point by itself), then any 8, then Forno cards, then whichever capture takes the most cards.

Keep the Pizza in your hand until it can capture. It is safe there. Play it when it takes an 8 or cards that add up to 8. And while the Pizza has not been seen, avoid leaving an 8, or cards that add up to 8, on the plate: that is an open door for whoever holds it.

Stop chasing a point that is decided. Each scoring point is worth 1, however big the margin. All You Can Eat is settled at 21 cards, Panetteria at 6 Forno cards, and the Dream Menu at three 8s. Once one is won or lost, turn to the others.

If the 8s split two each, the 1s decide. A tied Dream Menu goes to the player with the fewest 1s, then 2s and so on. When the 8s look like splitting, let the other side collect the 1s.

The last capture is worth extra cards. Whoever captures last takes everything left on the plate. In the final hand of the deck, try to keep a card that can capture for your last turn.

> **Example.** The plate holds a 2 and a 6, and you hold a 4 and a 9 with nothing to capture. Play the 9: the plate then adds up to 17 and cannot be swept. Playing the 4 would leave 12, also safe, but it puts a third low card on the plate.

Chef's Choice

Tanto di Cappello · 2, 3 or 4 players

The game is won with 10s and 9s. Those eight cards hold 84 of the 120 hat points. Winning many small tricks matters far less than winning the few that hold them.

Lead cards that give nothing away. With no good reason to do otherwise, lead a 5 or lower from a suit that is not trump. If it is beaten you have lost nothing.

Trump the big hats, with your smallest trump that does the job. The 1 of trumps beats the 10 of any other suit. Do not spend a trump on a trick with no hats in it, and do not spend the 10 of trumps where the 2 would win.

Bring your own 10s and 9s home safely. A plain 10 led into a table that still holds trumps is a gift. Play it when you are last and the trick is already yours, or onto a trick your partner is winning.

Count the ten trumps. The turned-up card is one of them. Once you know how many are left, and whether the 10 and 9 of trumps have gone, you know which of your cards are safe.

Watch the turned-up card as the stock runs out. It is the last card drawn, so it goes to whoever draws last. With two players that is the loser of the trick played when two cards remain. If it is the 10 or 9 of trumps, losing that trick cheaply can be the best play of the hand; if it is a low trump, win the trick and take the unknown card.

Plan the last three tricks. When the stock is gone nobody draws again. With two players and a careful count you can work out your opponent's three cards exactly. Try to reach this point holding a trump.

In teams, feed your partner. When your partner is winning the trick and you play after the opponents, add your biggest hat to it.

With three, mind the leader. Everyone plays alone, so the two players behind share an interest in keeping hats away from whoever is ahead.

Head Chef

Capo Cuoco · 5 players

Bid only as high as you must. The kitchen scores the same for making a bid of 61 as for a bid of 100. Every raise only lifts the target, so bid just enough to beat the last bid, and stop when the price is more than your hand is worth.

What a bidding hand looks like. Four or five cards of one suit, with its 10 or 9, make a trump suit. Add up the hats you expect to win yourself, then remember that your sous chef brings the called card (11 points if it is the 10) and whatever else they hold.

Do not bid just to push the price up. If everyone else passes, the contract is yours.

Call the highest trump you do not hold. Usually that is the 10; if you have it, call the 9. Your partner then holds the card that would otherwise beat you.

Cooking alone pays double. If your hand can make the bid without help, call a card you hold. You take on four players but score 2 points, not 1.

Head chef: lead trumps when you can. With the longest trump suit at the table, each round of trumps takes more from the diners than from you, and it often shows you who your sous chef is.

Sous chef: choose your moment. Until the called card is played, the diners are guessing. Give hats to tricks the head chef is winning, and save the called card for a trick that is worth winning. Do not reveal yourself for a trick with nothing in it.

Diners: find the sous chef. Watch who gives hats to the head chef and who avoids beating them. Until you know, do not add hats to a trick that an unknown player is winning.

Diners: know your target. The diners win by taking 121 minus the bid. Against a bid of 70 you need 51 hat points between the three of you, about five big cards.

Crowd Pleasers

Tre Stelle · 2 players, or 4 in teams

The 8s are the prize, and they are fragile. Each 8 carries 3 stars, but the 10 and 9 of its suit beat it. Twelve of the 32 stars in the deck sit on those four cards.

Protect an 8 with small cards. You must follow suit, so an 8 with two or three low cards beside it can duck while the 10 and 9 are played, and is then the best card left in its suit. An 8 with no company is in danger: give it to a trick your partner is winning as soon as you can.

Hunt an 8 when you hold the 10 or 9 above it. Lead the suit, and keep leading it. Each round strips away the small cards guarding the 8 until its holder has to play it.

Lead your longest suit. Once the other players have run out of it, every card you have left in that suit wins its trick, however small, and the others must throw cards away.

Throw away with care. When you cannot follow suit, give a starless card (4 to 1) to a trick the other team is winning, and an 8 or another star to a trick your partner is winning.

Use the table talk precisely. Say NomNom when you want the suit led back, for example when you hold the 9 and 8 and need your partner to win with the 10 first. Say Bleugh when you have length in the suit but no strength. Say Finished when you play your last card of a suit, so your partner knows you can throw stars on it next time. The other team hears every word, so stay silent when the message helps them more.

Listen to the declarations. A Feast or a Tasting Platter tells the whole table where several 10s, 9s and 8s are. Use what the other team declares to decide which of your 8s are safe.

Keep a winner for the end. The last trick is worth 3 points, the same as an 8. In the final tricks, hold on to a card you know will win.

Keep the score as you play. You may claim the win as soon as your team reaches 69, but a wrong claim loses the game. Add up your stars trick by trick, and claim when you are certain.

Take the re-deal. With fewer than 3 stars in your hand you may ask for a new deal. Take it.

With two players, remember the draws. Every card drawn from the stock is shown. Keep track of what your opponent has picked up and you will know much of their hand by the time the stock runs out.